roorq.com — B2B2C Thrift Fashion Strategy

A founder's working doc. Concrete mechanisms, no fluff. Built for a small team executing on a tight budget.

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0. The Wedge in One Line

> **Indian thrift sellers are stuck on Instagram DMs. We give them a WhatsApp AI listing bot + a real marketplace, and we take a small cut of the GMV they couldn't access before.**

Everything else in this doc serves that thesis.

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1. Business Model

Primary revenue: GMV commission (start lean, layer up)

- **8% commission** on every sale for the first year. This is below Meesho (~5–8%), competitive vs Etsy (6.5%) and far below offline thrift (50%+ markups). Low enough that no Instagram seller has a real reason to refuse.
- Move to **tiered commissions** once supply is locked in: 6% for top-rated sellers (rewards retention), 10% for new/unverified, 12% for "managed" sellers (we handle photography + pricing).

Secondary revenue (the "invisible" margin)

This is where the real money is. Commission alone won't fund a marketplace.

Stream	How it works	Realistic margin
Logistics arbitrage	Negotiate bulk rates with Shiprocket/Delhivery/Xpressbees. Charge sellers ₹70–90 per shipment, pay ₹45–60.	₹25–35 per order, scales with GMV
Payment float	Hold buyer payment 5 days post-delivery (legitimate dispute window). Park in liquid funds.	4–6% annualized on float
Pro vendor subscription	"roorq Pro" at ₹499/month: AI photo enhancement, priority placement, advanced analytics, lower commission tier.	Pure margin once built
Listing boosts	₹49 to bump an item to top of category for 24h, ₹149 for "drop spotlight."	95%+ margin
Authentication-as-a-service	₹99 per item for verified condition grade + brand authenticity check (initially manual + reference photos, later vision AI).	Trust premium, drives buyer conversion
Buyer membership	"roorq Inner Circle" at ₹199/month: 2-hour early access on drops, free shipping above ₹699, exclusive vendor sales.	Recurring, predictable
Returns insurance	₹29 add-on at checkout; covers no-questions-asked return. We pool the premiums; only ~10% of thrift items get returned.	60%+ margin on the line item
Trend data licensing (year 2+)	Sell aggregated category demand reports to D2C brands and resale platforms.	Very high margin, low ops

What we deliberately don't charge for: listing fees, joining fees, photography (in MVP). Anything that gates supply growth gets cut.

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2. Product Strategy

Buyer-side core features

1. **Drop-based discovery, not endless scroll.** Vendors release "drops" at scheduled slots (Fri 8pm, Sun 11am). Creates appointment behavior — same psychology as Supreme/Aimé Leon Dore but native to thrift's one-piece-only nature.
2. **Standardized measurements.** Every listing must have chest, length, sleeve, waist (whichever apply). The single biggest pain point in Instagram thrift is "will it fit me?" — we kill it. Buyers save their measurements once; we show "fits you" / "runs small" labels automatically.

3. **Aesthetic-first filters.** Categories like *Y2K, downtown, old money, coquette, gorpcore, indie sleaze* alongside boring "shirts/pants." This is how GenZ actually searches.
4. **Steal alerts.** User saves a search ("oversized blazer, M, under ₹1500") → push notification when a match drops. This is the retention killer feature. People check the app daily for the dopamine hit.
5. **The Story tab on every PDP.** Vendor's 1–2 line note: "Picked this up at a Bandra estate sale, original ₹6k Zara." Optional, rewarded with karma. Creates the storytelling layer Instagram thrift gets right.
6. **Wishlist + sold-out timeline.** Even after items sell, keep them visible with "sold in 4 mins" tags. Generates FOMO and signals platform velocity.

Vendor-side core features

1. **WhatsApp Listing Bot** (the wedge — full workflow below).
2. **Inventory dashboard** — what's live, what's sold, what's stale (>14 days, suggest re-shoot or discount).
3. **Suggested pricing engine** — based on sold comps in the same category/brand/condition. Just shows: "Similar items sold for ₹650–₹850 (median ₹720)."
4. **Order ops on WhatsApp.** New order → WhatsApp message with shipping label PDF → vendor drops at pickup point or schedules pickup. No new app to learn.
5. **Payouts every Tuesday + Friday.** Sellers care about cash flow more than fancy dashboards.

The WhatsApp AI Bot Workflow (vendor onboarding)

This is the moat in execution, not in concept. Anyone can copy the idea; few will execute the prompt engineering and edge-case handling well.

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Step 1: Vendor sends 3-6 photos of an item to the roorq WhatsApp number.
Step 2: Optional 10-30s voice note. ("This is a vintage Tommy Hilfiger, EUC, men's
L,
        thinking around 800 bucks.")
Step 3: Bot runs:
        - Vision model (Claude / GPT-4V) → category, color, brand visible on tag,
          condition signals (visible wear, missing buttons, stains).
        - Whisper → transcript of voice note for any details photos miss.
        - Pulls comparable sold listings → suggests price band.
Step 4: Bot replies in ONE message:
        "Got it. Detected: men's polo, Tommy Hilfiger (logo visible), navy.
         Condition looks Excellent. Comp price: ₹650-₹900.
         I need: chest measurement (pit-to-pit) and length.
         Reply: 'chest 54, length 70' or send a measuring tape photo."
Step 5: Vendor sends measurements + confirms.
Step 6: Bot generates listing draft → sends preview link → vendor taps "Publish."
        Live on roorq.com in under 90 seconds.
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Why this matters: the average IG thrift seller takes 8–12 minutes per listing today (caption, story posting, DMs about size). We compress that to under 2 minutes. That's the entire reason they migrate.

Differentiation vs Instagram thrift stores

Pain on Instagram	roorq solution
No search/filter	Real search, faceted filters, aesthetic tags
"Is it still available?" DMs	Real-time inventory
No size confidence	Mandatory measurements + your-size matching
Payment via UPI screenshots, no buyer protection	Escrow with 5-day dispute window
Logistics is the seller's problem	Aggregated rates + label generation
One-vendor catalog only	Cross-vendor discovery
Reviews? Reputation?	Verified ratings, vendor tier badges

We are *not* trying to kill Instagram for thrift. Sellers will keep posting there for marketing. We become the **transaction + trust layer underneath.**

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3. Retention & Growth Loops

Karma Credits (single most important retention mechanic)

- Earn karma by: leaving a photo review (+50), referring a friend who buys (+200), reselling something you bought from us (+100), uploading a #howIwore fit (+30), sharing a drop on Instagram with a tracked link (+20).
- Spend karma at 1 karma = ₹1, capped at 20% off any order. Never expires (low-cost commitment, high psychological stickiness).
- Why it works: it converts every customer touchpoint into a retention event without us paying cash for it. The "currency" is internal — we control the float.

Tier system (status > rewards)

Tier	Unlock	Perk
Drifter	Default	Standard access
Curator	3 purchases or 5 fits posted	30-min early drop access
Tastemaker	10 purchases + 4-star vendor rating	2-hour early access, profile badge
Icon	Invite-only based on community impact	Co-curated drops, vendor partnerships, free shipping for life

GenZ responds to status more than discounts. Make the badge visible on their profile and on every fit they post.

Resale loop (the closed circuit)

> Buy a piece on roorq → wear it → list it back on roorq → get karma bonus + cash. Repeat.

This is the **defensibility narrative for sustainability** AND a structural retention loop. Every item bought is a future listing. Each user becomes a vendor without realizing it. We get to a point where ~30% of supply comes from past buyers — that's a real moat.

Creator Shops

- Approved fashion creators (5k–500k followers) get a **"Rack"** — a curated collection of items from multiple vendors, branded with their name and aesthetic.
- Creator earns 3% of GMV from their rack (we eat this from our 8%, net 5% to us). They don't hold inventory; they curate.
- Creator gets analytics + a public profile they can promote on their socials.
- This solves cold-start on the demand side — creators bring their audiences and the platform gets free distribution.

UGC engine: #howIwore

- After delivery, prompt buyer to upload a fit photo wearing the item. Tag the listing.
- Photos appear on the original PDP as social proof (huge conversion lift — like Amazon reviews but for fit).
- Best monthly fit gets ₹2000 + featured spot. Cheap acquisition channel via earned virality.

Network effects (the actual moat math)

1. **Cross-side network effect:** more vendors → more variety → more buyers → more sales velocity → more vendors. Standard marketplace flywheel.
2. **Same-side buyer effect (this is rare and powerful):** more buyers leaving fit photos and reviews → buyers trust the platform more than IG → more buyers convert.
3. **Same-side vendor effect:** sold-comp data improves with more transactions → pricing engine gets better → vendors price more accurately → faster sell-through → vendors prefer roorq over IG.

Effect (2) and (3) are what Instagram structurally cannot replicate.

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4. GenZ Positioning

Brand voice

- "Pre-loved," not "secondhand." "Curated," not "used." Language matters.
- Tone: dry, slightly internet-poisoned, never corporate. Instagram captions like "₹750 for a jacket that costs ₹6k new and looked at one Mumbai monsoon and survived."
- No greenwashing. Don't say "save the planet." Say "skip Shein, look better doing it."

Sustainability — but as a side effect, not a sermon

- Every PDP shows a small "**you'd save ~2.4 kg CO_2 vs buying new**" line. Quietly there, never the headline.
- Annual "**roorq Wrapped**" — your year on the platform: how many pieces you bought, sold, total CO_2 saved, your most-worn fit. Ships in December. Built for screenshotting → free distribution.

Storytelling layer

- Every vendor has a profile page with their story (where they source, why they started). Required field at signup, even if 2 sentences.

- Top vendors get long-form profiles done by us — "Inside Aanya's Bandra Loft" — distributed on Instagram, YouTube Shorts, and as in-app discovery.

Trust mechanisms (non-negotiable for thrift)

1. **Photo verification at listing.** Bot rejects listings with stock photos or watermarks from other sellers (reverse image search).
2. **Verified Vendor badge.** Earned after 10 successful sales + 4.5-star rating + GST/PAN verification.
3. **Escrow as default.** Buyer pays roorq, vendor sees "payment confirmed," ships within 48h, payout 5 days post-delivery. Same model as eBay/Mercari.
4. **No-questions-asked returns within 48h of delivery** (with optional Returns Insurance). Removes the biggest blocker for first-time thrift buyers — fit anxiety.
5. **Public dispute resolution stats.** "98% of disputes resolved in <72h" on every PDP. Transparency is the trust hack.

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5. Tech Stack (practical, optimized for cost)

Recommended stack

- **Frontend web:** Next.js 14 + Tailwind. Hosted on Vercel (free tier covers MVP).
- **Mobile:** React Native (Expo) — share ~70% code with web. Don't build native iOS/Android separately at MVP.
- **Backend:** Node.js (Fastify) or Python (FastAPI). Pick whichever your team is faster in. Don't bikeshed this.
- **Database:** PostgreSQL on Supabase (free tier → cheap paid tier). You get auth, storage, and DB in one. Revisit at ~50k users.
- **Search:** Typesense (self-hosted) or Meilisearch. Algolia is great but pricing breaks at scale.
- **Storage/CDN:** Cloudflare R2 for images (no egress fees — huge cost saver vs S3 for image-heavy product).
- **Cache/queue:** Redis (Upstash for serverless).
- **Payments:** Razorpay (Standard Checkout + Route for split payouts to vendors).
- **Logistics:** Shiprocket API (don't build your own, no reason to).
- **WhatsApp:** Meta Cloud API direct (skip BSPs like Gupshup until you outgrow rate limits — saves 60–70% on cost).
- **Analytics:** PostHog (self-host or cloud — has product analytics + feature flags + session replay in one).
- **Transactional email/SMS:** Resend + MSG91.

High-leverage AI use cases — do these:

1. **Vendor onboarding (Vision + LLM):** auto-extract category, brand, color, condition from photos + voice note. This is the wedge feature, worth investing real prompt engineering effort.
2. **Pricing engine:** train a simple regression on sold comps (category × brand × condition × season). Don't overcomplicate — even XGBoost beats vibes-based pricing. Surface as a suggestion, never enforce.
3. **Recommendations:** start with simple collaborative filtering ("buyers who bought this also bought") + content-based ("similar aesthetic"). Don't build a fancy two-tower model in year one.
4. **Fraud/anomaly detection:** flag listings with reverse-image-matched stolen photos, prices >3σ below comps, vendors with >5% dispute rate. Mostly rule-based + simple ML.
5. **Auto-moderation of UGC:** vision model checks #howIwore uploads for nudity, hate symbols, etc. before publish.

AI hype to skip:

- ❌ AI-generated outfit recommendations (people want curation, not algorithmic vibes — at least not yet).
- ❌ Virtual try-on (cool demo, not why people don't buy thrift; measurements solve 90% of fit anxiety at 1% of the cost).
- ❌ AI chatbot for buyer support (humans are cheaper at <10k DAU, and bots break trust when they fail).

On blockchain

Skip it entirely. No real authentication problem in Indian thrift requires on-chain provenance. NFT receipts add cost and friction without solving a buyer pain. If a luxury resale vertical opens up later (like Vestiaire), revisit.

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6. Go-to-Market

First 100 vendors (months 1–3)

- **Manual outreach to top 200 Instagram thrift accounts.** Build a list using Instagram search + tools like Phantombuster. Filter for accounts with 5k+ followers and visible posting frequency.
- **Pitch:** "0% commission for 90 days, free pro photos for top 10 SKUs (use a freelancer at ₹150/photo), guaranteed 50+ free buyers in your first week via our launch drop."

- **Onboarding sprint:** founders personally onboard the first 30. No automation. You learn what breaks.
- **IIT Roorkee angle:** student-run thrift collectives at IITR. Easy first 10–20 vendors with built-in trust because of the .com name. Replicate at IIT Delhi, IIT Bombay, NIFT Delhi, Symbiosis Pune.

First 10,000 users (months 3–6)

1. **Drop Fest launch event.** 20–30 vendors drop simultaneously on a Friday night. Treat it like an IPL. Press release to The Voice of Fashion, POPxo, LBB. Live on Instagram with vendor reels.
2. **Campus ambassador program.** 30 colleges, 1–2 ambassadors each. Pay in karma credits + commission on sign-ups (₹30 per first-purchase user). IIT Roorkee is the home base — host the launch event there.
3. **Influencer seeding:**
   - 50 nano (10–50k) thrift/fashion creators get free Creator Shops + ₹2k onboarding credit.
   - 10 micro (50–200k) creators get a paid partnership (₹15–30k each) for the launch drop.
   - Avoid macros — terrible ROI for a marketplace.
4. **Reddit + niche communities:** r/IndianFashionAddicts, r/Frugal_Ind, r/IndiaInvestments (sustainability angle), Discord servers around streetwear/Y2K.
5. **The "Bring Your Vendor" referral.** A buyer who refers a successful new vendor gets ₹500 in karma credits. Distributes acquisition cost to your existing users.

IIT Roorkee leverage (specifically)

- The `.com` is already a campus inside-joke advantage — own it.
- **Cognizance + Thomso (IITR's tech and cultural fests):** sponsor a "thrift swap" booth, collect emails, host a campus-wide "drop your wardrobe" donation drive that also seeds initial vendor inventory.
- **Alumni network:** IITR alumni at every major Indian VC, Flipkart, Myntra, Meesho. Use it for advisor circle and warm intros to investors at seed.
- **Founding team narrative:** if you're an IITR student/alum, lean into the story. Indian press loves "IIT founder" hooks.

MVP (build in 8–10 weeks)

Build only these. Anything else is scope creep.

1. WhatsApp listing bot (vendor side) — the wedge.
2. Web marketplace with: home/feed, category browse, search, PDP, cart, checkout (Razorpay), order tracking.
3. Vendor dashboard (basic): orders, earnings, payouts, listings management.
4. Buyer accounts: auth (phone OTP), profile, orders, wishlist.
5. Shiprocket integration for label generation + pickup scheduling.
6. Manual ops dashboard for you (founder) to handle disputes, fraud flags, vendor verification.

Skip for MVP: mobile app, karma credits, creator shops, recommendations engine, returns insurance, drops calendar UI. All these come post-MVP once you have transaction data.

3-month roadmap

Month	Focus	Goal
Month 1	Build MVP, recruit pilot cohort. Founders manually onboard 30 vendors. Listings start going live in week 4.	30 vendors, 200 listings, 50 test purchases
Month 2	Soft launch. First Drop Fest. Influencer seeding. Karma system v1. Iterate on bot edge cases.	100 vendors, 1500 listings, ₹4–6L GMV
Month 3	Mobile app (Expo). Creator Shops launch. First trend report internally for vendors. Begin expansion to Bombay + Delhi vendors.	250 vendors, 5000 users, ₹15–20L GMV

Cost-conscious budget (first 6 months, INR)

Line item	Monthly	6-month total
Infra (Vercel, Supabase, R2, etc.)	₹8k–15k	~₹70k
WhatsApp Cloud API	₹3k–8k (scales with volume)	~₹35k
AI/LLM API (Claude/OpenAI)	₹10k–25k	~₹120k
Shiprocket subscription	₹2k	₹12k
Razorpay (no fixed cost, per-txn)	—	—

Line item	Monthly	6-month total
Founder photography fund (top vendors)	₹15k	~₹50k (first 2 months)
Influencer seeding (10 micros)	—	₹2L (one-time)
Drop Fest launch event	—	₹50k–80k
Tools (PostHog, Resend, etc.)	₹3k	₹18k
Legal (entity, ToS, privacy)	—	₹40k (one-time)
Total estimated		**₹6–8L for 6 months**

This is achievable with founder-funded runway or a small angel round (₹25–40L for 12-month runway with 2 founders + 1 dev).

Path to first revenue

- Week 6 of MVP: first transactions begin (you keep 0% commission for pilot).
- Week 14: switch on 8% commission.
- Week 20: enable Pro subscriptions + listing boosts.
- Month 6: revenue mix should look like — 70% commission, 15% logistics margin, 10% subs+boosts, 5% other. Total monthly run rate of ₹2–4L by end of month 6, ₹15–25L by month 12 if vendor count hits 800+.

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8. What Will Break First (so you're ready)

Honest list, in order of likelihood:

1. **Vendor side will lie about condition.** You'll get disputes by week 3. Build the dispute workflow before launch, not after.
2. **The bot will misclassify brands** — Indian unbranded "thrift" often has cut tags. Have a manual review queue from day one.
3. **Two-sided cold start.** First 1000 buyers will land, browse, and bounce because supply is thin. Solution: launch with a single "Drop Fest" rather than evergreen browsing — concentrates demand on concentrated supply.
4. **Logistics last-mile.** Damaged/lost packages are 2–4% in India. Returns insurance partially covers this; build the ops muscle early.
5. **Vendor poaching by Meesho/Flipkart 2nd Hand.** Your moat isn't "we exist" — it's the bot + community + brand + creator integration. Lean into all four hard.

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9. The 6-Month North Star

> 800 active vendors, 50k registered users, 8k MAU buyers, ₹40L monthly GMV, ₹4–5L monthly revenue, 35% MoM growth, NPS >50, 30%+ of buyers have made a repeat purchase.

Hit those and you have a Series A story. Miss them and you have a clear set of things to fix.

Last updated: working draft. Edit ruthlessly — this doc is a tool, not a deliverable.